

CIAL
COCHIN INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT LIMITED

Flying into a Sustainable Future



S Suhas IAS
Managing Director, CIAL

Cochin International Airport Limited (CIAL), an international airport serving the city of Kochi in Kerala is the world's first airport fully powered by solar energy. CIAL has become an iconic symbol of sustainable aviation and operational excellence. With a strong commitment to environmental responsibility and passenger satisfaction, it has garnered international recognition for its innovative initiatives and cutting-edge infrastructure.

CIAL's journey has been nothing short of remarkable. From its inception as India's first Greenfield airport built through a public-private partnership (PPP) mode, CIAL has continuously pushed boundaries and set new standards in the aviation industry. In an exclusive interview with India Today, **S Suhas IAS, Managing Director, CIAL** delved into the exceptional journey of the airport, its resilience during challenging times, and its unwavering commitment to sustainable aviation, passenger satisfaction, and future growth. Excerpts of the interview...

How did CIAL adapt to the unprecedented circumstances brought about by the COVID-19 pandemic, and what strategies were implemented to overcome the challenges?

The challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic were immense, and we witnessed a significant decline in various aspects, particularly in passenger movement. Reviving the systems and restoring profitability was a herculean task, but through cohesive teamwork and strategic planning, we were able to achieve remarkable results. In the fiscal year 2021-22, CIAL registered a profit of Rs 37 crore, becoming India's only airport to witness a profit after COVID-19. FY 2022-23 was exceptional for us. ***The company has logged a profit (after tax) of Rs. 262.68 Cr. This is a record figure in the 25-year operational history of CIAL***. The year also fetched us the prestigious Airport Service Quality award-2022 instituted by Airport Council International (ACI).

In what ways do you inspire and motivate individuals to deliver their best for the organisation?

As the Managing Director of CIAL for almost two years, I believe in the power of participative management to inspire and motivate my team. Through restructuring initiatives and delegation of work, we ensure active involvement of every employee. I prioritise engagement by encouraging open communication, welcoming their ideas, complaints, and suggestions. My endeavour has been to empower the team, create a respectful environment, and foster a sense of ownership and shared responsibility.

What lies on the horizon for CIAL in terms of future plans and aspirations?

We intend to make Kochi a 'hub for air traffic in South India'. During the post-pandemic period, CIAL is witnessing almost 96% of passenger traffic at par with that of the pre-pandemic era. In the last one and half years, the company commissioned three prestigious projects- the 12 MW solar plant in Payyanur, 4.5 MW run-of-the-river project at Arippara, and the exquisite Business Jet Terminal, which eyes a surge in affordable chartered flying. CIAL has an impressive portfolio of 163 projects, wherein 9 of them are of paramount importance.

We are focusing on multiple non-aero revenue streams to garner a sustainable income. Our 5-star hotel project is going to be operated by the renowned IHCL- TAJ group and also a luxury transit accommodation is under construction. In terms of airport operations, CIAL is trying to expand air travel options by introducing new international routes and establishing crucial connections to various destinations. We are launching Kerala's first direct flight to Vietnam through VietJet soon. Looking ahead, CIAL is actively exploring opportunities to add European sectors, with plans to establish more direct connections to Europe by next year.

The business jet terminal has already facilitated around 400 jet operations, and CIAL anticipates an increase in business jet traffic, with an average of 1000 jets and 5 landings per day in the upcoming year. Additionally, CIAL is focused on achieving remarkable financial success in the ongoing fiscal year, aiming to reach the 1000-crore club and surpass expectations. The Chief Minister of Kerala who is the Chairman of the company, and board of directors have been instrumental in providing immense support and guidance to CIAL. We are also thankful to the support we get from the Ministry of Civil Aviation. Their vision in matters related to the development of the company has played a crucial role in shaping the strategies and initiatives, contributing significantly to its success.